

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

Medavakkam » Srinivasa Nagar » Kathipara Junction » Kovilambakkam » Sadasivam Nagar » Potheri » Selaiyur » Sembakkam » St.Thomas Mount » Madipakkam » Urappakkam » Paranur

Narrow stretch, traders' extensions and inadequate parking on Station Road worsen congestion; commuters seek relocation of shops and better traffic management

T. ARVIND

The approach road to Chromepet railway station from Radha Nagar Station Road has steadily narrowed over the years owing to encroachments by shops, causing severe hardship to rail and bus commuters, pedestrians and office-goers, particularly during peak hours.

Hundreds of commuters using Station Road on the eastern side of the railway station are forced to navigate multiple bottlenecks every day. Residents and activists point to shop encroachments on the southern side of the road as the primary cause of the congestion, which is further aggravated by illegal parking, two-way traffic movement and a narrow stretch near the road's end close to the railway foot overbridge. While the eastern portion of the road remains relatively wide, the carriageway progressively narrows towards the station, resulting in crowding and delays.

According to local activists, around 34 shops on the southern side of Station Road were constructed by the then Pallavaram

Encroachments choke Station Road access to Chromepet station



Station Road near Chromepet railway station. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND

Municipality in 1978.

"The land was originally provided by the Madras Institute of Technology (MIT) for laying a road. However, shops were later constructed there, and they have now become a major obstacle to public movement," said a trader and activist who did not wish to be named. He added that the municipality had also built eight shops on Bashyam Street and 12 on Bharathi Street, both located near Station Road. "Most of these establishments function along key access routes, contributing to traffic congestion during peak hours. Relocating the shops to an alternative site with wider road access would help

ease the situation while protecting livelihoods," he said.

Parking woes

Commuters said the absence of dedicated parking facilities at branches of Karur Vysya Bank and Indian Bank on the stretch has compounded the problem.

"Customers park two-wheelers and sometimes even cars wherever they find space. The banks should provide adequate parking facilities or consider relocating from such a narrow road," said Dheeraj, a customer.

Daily commuters say the narrowing of the road has significantly affected their routine.



"We use a road that is barely 15 feet wide, and portions of it are further occupied by encroachments. A considerable amount of our energy is spent negotiating the congestion every morning," said N. Gurumurthi, who travels daily by EMU train to Egmore.

Senior social activist V. Santhanam recalled a recent incident in which a woman rushing to catch a train fell while trying to pass through a constricted stretch between an autorickshaw and a shop signboard jutting into the road. "Such incidents should not recur," he said.

He added that loading and unloading of goods during peak hours

is a common occurrence and that larger vehicles often reverse onto the road after deliveries, worsening traffic snarls.

An official said traders had been repeatedly advised to confine their activities within their allotted spaces and avoid extending beyond the stormwater drain. However, many continue to place signboards and merchandise on the road, reducing the available carriageway.

Residents and commuters have urged the Tambaram Corporation either to relocate the shops on the southern side of Station Road or to enforce stricter regulations and improve traffic management through regular monitoring.

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▼ The damaged steps at the Pazhavanthangal subway.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Poor maintenance at subway poses risk to walkers

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

For months, the entrance from Ellaiaimman Kovil Street in Pazhavanthangal to the subway has been fraught with risk for pedestrians.

The steps leading to the walkway, the platforms at the Pazhavanthangal railway station, and to MGR Nagar are broken, posing a risk to pedestrians and commuters, says V. Rama Rao, advisor of the Federation of Nanganallur (Re-

sidents) Welfare Association.

The underpass comes under the Bus Routes Roads Department of Greater Chennai Corporation.

"If pedestrians are not careful while navigating the broken steps, they risk falling. Additionally, passengers boarding trains with luggage face even greater difficulty and risk," says Rama Rao.

The railings along the steps, from Ellaiaimman Kovil Street to MGR Nagar and from the locality to the subway, along the station entrance are missing.

Near the platform entrance, the walkway slab is broken and has become loose; when a pedestrian steps on it, they can lose their balance and fall.

A majority of pedestrians prefer the route from Ellaiaimman Kovil Street, leading to MGR Nagar, along the lane towards Fourth Main Road, Nanganallur, with a few hitting the opposite side.

Additionally, the walkway is littered with trash, contributing to unhygienic conditions for those using the subway.

Ensure basic amenities in New Perungalathur

V. DHANASEKHARAN

We residents of New Perungalathur want the State government to provide basic amenities to our region.

The neighbourhood lacks an underground drainage network, drinking water supply and good

roads. During the regime of the previous government, there was a proposal to construct a drainage network in the Madambakkam, Chitlapakkam, Perungalathur-Peerkankaranai, and Sembakkam regions at a cost of ₹890 crore. However, the project is yet to take off.

Individual homes and apart-

ments have septic tanks making groundwater highly contaminated.

Residents have to rely on water cans.

Apart from this, the roads are in a highly deplorable condition, and it is risky for two-wheeler riders, in particular senior citizens.

'Extend Chembarambakkam drinking water pipeline'



M. RAVI

On June 2, residents of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar in Chitlapakkam received Palar drinking water supplied by the Tamil Nadu Water Supply and Drainage Board.

Following my representation regarding irregular Palar drinking water supply to D. Sarath Kumar,

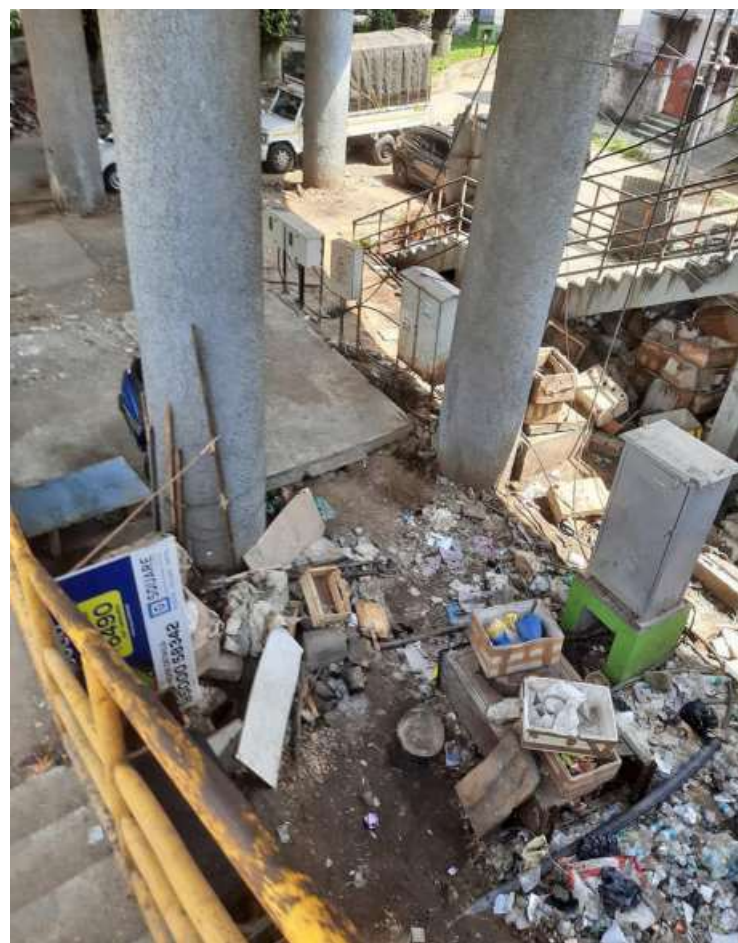
Tambaram assembly constituency MLA, and Minister for Human Resources Management and Ex-Servicemen Welfare (portfolios), the needful was done.

The ruling Tamilaga Vetri Kazhagam Chengalpattu district functionaries too called and enquired about the water supply and asked us to contact them if any issues regarding water supply arise.

The Tambaram City Municipal Corporation and the Sembakkam Zone of the Corporation should hold talks with the Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board to extend the Chembarambakkam Drinking Water pipeline to Duraisamy Nagar, Ambedkar Nagar and Sri Sarvamangala Nagar in Chitlapakkam, which is located adjacent to Thiru Vi Ka Nagar and Saraswathi Colony, till the issue is resolved.

Further, the Corporation should request the State government to levy a uniform water and sewerage taxes for the residents of localities in the Chitlapakkam and Pallavaram regions. The taxes vary causing confusion and worry among consumers.

M. Ravi is the secretary of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents' Association, Chitlapakkam



▼ Garbage dumped below the Madras Institute of Technology flyover in Chrompet. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Unpleasant walk from MIT campus to bus stop

ARUNKUMAR JAGANNATHAN

Awalk from the Madras Institute of Technology campus in Chrompet to the bus stop is a nightmare. Mounds of waste is strewn around with vehicles encroaching pedestrian space, making last-mile connectivity a complete mess.

Along the MIT foot overbridge, bottles are stacked on the roof of a public toilet (along the staircases). The stormwater drain network is choked with plastics and is a breeding ground for mosquitoes. The pathways are broken. Tambaram City Municipal Corporation should prioritize all these public concerns.

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volunteer writer**

Dear readers, you can be our volunteer-writer by writing to us about issues and events in your neighbourhood. You should send the write-ups to downtownfeedback@thehindu.co.in. Letters must carry the contact number

Petitions presented to Alandur MLA

A time frame for issuing patta, monthly readings for electricity charges and desilting of Adambakkam lake are on the list of demands

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

The office-bearers of the Federation of Nanganallur (Residents) Welfare Association, led by its advisor V. Rama Rao, submitted a wish list outlining the long-standing demands of the region to the newly elected MLA of the Alandur Assembly constituency, M. Harish.

S. Chandrabose, president, and P. V. Inbasekaran, joint secretary of the federation participated.

V. Rama Rao requested Harish to take up with the Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay the issue of 'patta' without any corruption and delay.

"The State government should fix a time period for issuing 'patta'. If the time period is exceeded after the petitioner has completed the requisite paperwork (reasons for non-issuance), the Tahsildar's office should pay a fine of ₹ 250 per



The office-bearers of the Federation of Nanganallur (Residents) Welfare Association with Alandur MLA M. Harish.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

day, as per the RTI Act rules," said Rama Rao.

Overhead EB cables

The overhead power cables in Nanganallur, Alandur, Pazhavanthangal, and Adambakkam regions

should be laid underground, and EB readings should be taken on a monthly basis, as in other areas, says S. Chandrabose. There is a need to install a 110 kV substation, but due to space constraints, it has not been upgraded. The Tamil Na-

du Power Distribution Corporation Limited should adopt GIS (Gas Insulated System) Technology. For this, only around 10 grounds are needed. The GIS technology has been implemented in RA Puram, Mylapore and Mandaiveli, said Chandrabose.

Other demands

Desilting and deepening the Adambakkam Lake, constructing ghoslas for cattle and revision of property tax are among other demands residents have placed. They have also asked for an auditorium at a park behind Panachi Amman Temple; a road overbridge over Thillai Ganga Nagar subway to help people reach Nanganallur and adjoining areas, as the subway gets flooded, and creation of a traffic junction outside the Meenambakkam subway to help the motorists avoid taking a detour for a U-turn to access GST Road western lane (towards Saint Thomas Mount).

'Ensure livelihood support for workers'

Nesamani Nagar Residents' Welfare Association (NNRWA) in Perumbakkam has requested the Perumbakkam Village Panchayat and the Tamil Nadu Local Bodies Ombudsman to make effective use of the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme.

From July 1, the work under the employment guarantee scheme will increase from 100 to 125 days and be renamed 'Viksit Bharat-Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin)'.

N. K. Raja, president of NNRWA, says that the workers can be utilised to desilt rainwater channels, carry out monsoon pre-

paredness work at waterbodies, and help in road formation.

"Earlier, the Perumbakkam Village Panchayat had said that roads that have not been laid will be done after the elections are over. Now that a new government has assumed charge, the Panchayat should prioritise the formation of roads."

The Tamil Nadu Local Bodies Ombudsman has assured the residential association that it will implement the scheme effectively and also issue a directive to the Panchayat in this regard. The work will ensure the village's cleanliness and the livelihoods of workers."



Picture used for representational purposes only.
PHOTO: SRIRAM M. A.

It's play time at the Airport



▼ A new children's play area has come up at Chennai Airport Terminal, allowing children to unwind while they wait for the arrival of the flight.
PHOTO: RAGHUNATHAN SR

Extend the roof at this bus stop in Tambaram

T. SAKUNTHALA

The Tambaram City Municipal Corporation should consider extending the roof at the Tambaram railway station stop.

Although a row of shelters exist, they do not provide adequate protection from the heat.

As a result, some commuters avoid waiting under the shelter. Some can be seen sitting on the elevated pathway or standing on the opposite side.

This situation is made more hazardous by the proximity of buses entering and halting at the design-



nated area.

Commuters travel towards Kilambakkam, Kelambakkam, Mammallapuram, Chengalpattu, Thiruporur, and Kovalam. Extending the

roofs would offer much-needed comfort and safety for commuters who use this facility daily.

T. Sakunthala is a resident of Tambaram

A green carpet rolled out to nature enthusiasts

Bushwalk corridor, a community-built green space along the Buckingham Canal behind House of Hiranandani Upscale in Egattur on Old Mahabalipuram Road serves as a venue for guided bushwalks and birding sessions, as it did on World Environment Day

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

A patch of burnt soil, damaged drip irrigation pipes and blackened tree trunks now mark a section of what is called Bushwalk corridor along Buckingham Canal in Egattur, thanks to a fire that swept through it roughly a fortnight ago. Residents of House of Hiranandani Upscale had ploughed in considerable resources to build this green corridor, located in the space along the Canal, behind the towers. And they would have to allocate more resources to repair and restore the damaged elements. But this setback did not hold The Bushwalk Trust which manages the corridor from going ahead with a public event on World Environment Day (June 5), a walk down the Bushwalk corridor offered to both residents and guests. From time to time, the 'green' carpet is rolled out to nature enthusiasts from anywhere.

Along the way, the corridor had grown massive enough to make administration by a trust necessary. The corridor supports 12,000 plants and serves as a space for guided bushwalks and birding sessions.

The seeds of a green corridor were sown ironically during a "dry" period, the pandemic. Around 3,000 saplings of Arjuna tree had been planted along the Buckingham canal under a Tamil Nadu government urban forestry initiative. "There was no mechan-



ism to ensure their survival," recalls Shanthi Jothilingam, Treasurer of Bushwalk Trust. "Many residents assumed the agency that planted the saplings would continue maintaining them. But when that did not happen, a few volun-

teers stepped in." Among them was R. Shankar, a resident whose commitment would eventually shape the future of the landscape. Having left his job during the pandemic, Shankar found himself spending more time within the community



Images from the World Environment Day walk at Bushwalk corridor; a male Golden oriole photographed at the corridor.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND E. ARUN KUMAR

and became increasingly concerned about the fate of the saplings.

"We felt that if we did not act at that stage, thousands of saplings would simply be lost," he recalls. Residents pooled in funds, hired water tankers and spent weekends watering the saplings. The terrain was uneven and covered in dense undergrowth, making access difficult. Volunteers often filled drums with water and carried buckets across the site to reach the plants.

"It was physically demanding work," says Shanthi. "People would come before work, after work or whenever they found time and chip in."

Saplings grew, so did the scope of the initiative. Through Exnora International, the group established ties with Gayatri Trust, which later extended financial sup-

port. Around the same time, Shankar identified an opportunity to utilise groundwater emerging from nearby construction activity instead of allowing it to flow into the Buckingham Canal. The water was tested, found suitable for irrigation and channelled into a pond constructed with external support. From there, a drip irrigation system and sprinklers were installed across the site, dramatically reducing dependence on water tankers and creating a more sustainable maintenance model.

As the project expanded, residents realised the initiative needed a formal structure. The Bushwalk Trust was subsequently established as a legally registered trust, enabling it to receive institutional funding, employ dedicated gardeners and manage its finances transparently.

Children are often at the centre of programmes by The Bushwalk Trust. Plantation drives encourage them to plant saplings and monitor their growth, while nature-based activities foster a deeper connection with the environment.

The corridor has also emerged as an unexpected biodiversity hotspot. E. Arun Kumar, a resident naturalist who has been documenting wildlife in the area since 2021, says the habitat now supports a rich variety of resident and migratory bird species.

"We have documented 176 bird species here," he says. "Every few months, we organise bird walks, particularly during winter when migratory birds arrive. Many children who attend develop a lasting interest in birdwatching and nature."



This beauty queen is a barrier breaker

A hearing-impaired school girl, 16-year-old Saarikha Jagadeesh has been crowned Miss Teen Tamil Nadu 2026. Her answer at the beauty pageant truthfully reflects what she does off stage: using her earnings from her modelling assignments to support children with special needs



▼ Saarikha Jagadeesh being crowned Miss Teen Tamil Nadu by Miss Universe India Manika Vishwakarma at a pageant held on May 29. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tra Hearing Care under whose care she is since the age of two. “To build her confidence, I used to encourage her to look at the mirror and say ‘she looks like a queen,’” says Srividya. That was important because Saarikha did face bullying at school. Under the banner of “Global Raising Challengers Organisation”, Saarikha has given whatever she earned through modelling assignments to support other special needs children. Her first major stage event was at age of 11, where she won the “Junior Miss India” organised by Madarase Universal. There has been no looking back since then. Junior Miss Fab Star, Grand Gala Fashion Week, photo shoots for advertisements and a small role in a film only boosted her confidence.

For the World Fashion Week in Dubai in 2024, she took along three other children with special needs to walk the ramp along with her, training many of them to face the stage confidently.

In 2025, she conducted Tiranga, an inclusive event where 214 children walked the ramp to enter the London Book of Records.

Saarikha admits that making friends was not easy and she took the taunts as a challenge to prove others wrong.

“As a young girl with hearing disability, I know what my parents had to go through to meet my medical expense; the medication that was needed to improve my speech,” says Saarikha. “Modelling gave me confidence. I want other children like me who cannot walk, speak, see and those with Down’s Syndrome to achieve their dreams,” says Saarikha who wants to pursue a career in law.

Srividya remembers the tough search that had to be undertaken to find a swimming coach for her. Finally, an academy took it as a challenge to train Saarikha under water.

The family has a long list of people to thank starting with their former neighbour Kalpana D. Kumar, a speech pathologist. Kalpana nudged them to start early inter-

vention for the little girl.

Behind the young model’s elegant wardrobe is Sasirekha, chief designer at Sasi’s Bangalore Designer, who generously designs her costumes free of charge. A. Saffiberry, founder of Madrase Universal, who saw potential in Saarikha at 11 and continues to mentor her; and Malik, a casting director, who gave her an opportunity to act in *Goat* movie.

Actor Nayana Sai, founder of Southernwoods Model Academy, who has been training Saarikha, says she is a keen observer and a fast learner who can execute things the way you want.

“Even if she is not able to hear certain words, she tries to grasp my lip movement and respond. At times when her hearing aid stopped functioning, she observes and picks up. Pronouncing ‘R’ or ‘S’ word has been difficult but she worked on it,” says Nayana, who has trained more than 150 models.

Agreeing with Nayana, Saffiberry says Silambam moves she performed during the talent round she had learnt in just two weeks time. It gave the audience goosebumps, he says.

Srividya says her husband, Jagadeesh V, was not keen on modelling but never discouraged Saarikha. Jagadeesh ferries her to the many classes she attends.



LIFY THOMAS

Miss Teen Tamil Nadu 2026 Saarikha Jagadeesh’s answer in the question-and-answer round was in earnest, and no empty rhetoric. What she has done in the past points unerringly to that conclusion.

Asked what she would invent to help the world and why, 16-year-old Saarikha replied:

“I would not invent. Instead, I would create opportunities for the underprivileged and the differently abled because I believe that true beauty lies in helping others. Through my initiative, the Global Raising Challengers Organisation I am doing that.”

Saarikha had been diagnosed with bilateral profound hearing

loss as an infant, and the combination early intervention and modern technology has ensured that the world of sound was not shut out for her.

After early intervention at Balavidyalaya, the school for young deaf children in Adyar, till the age of five, Saarikha joined regular schooling starting with St. Francis International School in Kolapakkam followed by Velammal Bodhi Campus in Mugalivakkam. The hearing aid is her constant companion and her lifeline through which she does everything like a normal child. Saarikha is a Class XI student of Ology Tech School in Mugalivakkam.

Saarikha got started on modelling early.

Behind Saarikha’s foray into modelling was her mother Srividya J., and audiologist Dr Rajarajan of As-

23 participants at grand finale



▼ The winners of Miss Universe Tamil Nadu 2026 seen with (second from right) Nandini Nagaraj.

The grand finale of Miss Universe Tamil Nadu 2026 was held on May 29, 2026 at Taj Fisherman’s Cove, bringing together aspiring contestants from across the state in a celebration of beauty, confi-

dence, talent and empowerment.

Twenty-three contestants were in the fray across Miss Universe Tamil Nadu and Miss Teen Tamil Nadu categories.

The panel of judges included

Amjad Khan, director of franchise operations, MUI; Nikhil Anand, national director Miss Universe India; Vaamshi Uday, Miss Universe Karnataka 2025 winner; Kamakshi, Miss Universe Tamil Nadu 2025 winner; and Manika Vishwakarma, Miss Universe India.

According to a release, the winners of Miss Universe Tamil Nadu 2026 are Vaishnavi (winner); Pramiti (first runner-up); and Nikita (second runner-up). Saarikha was declared winner of the Miss Teen Tamil Nadu 2026.

The event showcased not only beauty and fashion but confidence, leadership, and individuality, providing a platform for young women to inspire and make a meaningful impact, said the release.

Nandini Nagaraj, state director for Tamil Nadu and Karnataka, who organised the event, said the success of Miss Universe Tamil Nadu 2026 marks another milestone in empowering women and nurturing future ambassadors who represent grace, intelligence, and purpose.



▼
C.T. Natesan, captain of Santhome Higher Secondary School receiving the T.N.C.A. Silver Jubilee Trophy from R.B. Alaganan, vice president, T.N.C.A. in 1983; and former Santhome coach Srinivasa Rao with cricketer Sai Sudharsan.
PHOTOS: THE HINDU ARCHIVES & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

LAKSHMY HARIKRISHAN

When two Santhome school watchers meet, cricket enters their conversation as surely as weather does when two Englishmen have a chat. The topic for this column came up on the sidelines of a discussion about the Golden Jubilee Reunion of 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School slated for June 7. While sifting through the accomplishments of the 1976 batch, the inevitable question was asked: "Any alumni from the 1976 batch made it to the national or state cricket team?" In the 1970s, Santhome school was on the way to cricketing greatness, but not until the mid-1980s would it be spoken of in glowing terms for its cricket. From the 1980s, the school produced cricketing giants who have embellished Tamil Nadu and India teams. Never mind that the 1976 batch cannot contribute to the topic. Recollections of Santhome cricket's golden decades seem to have perennial topicality never paling on Madras nostalgia hunters, even if the memory synapse fires from the 1980s.

T20 before T20 arrived

Before the T20 fever gripped cricket aficionados, Santhome Higher Secondary School was in the grip of an even more truncated form of cricket. Practice matches were always clipped short, often into one-fourth the span of the current T20 match, encouraging players to go hell for leather and the bowlers to "deliver" in the ridiculously few deliveries they got to bowl. "Players were trained to score quickly and make every over count," recalls former coach Srinivasa Rao. The sense of urgency while wielding the willow as well as the leather was particularly evident in the 1983-84 season, when at the Swami

Santhome cricket lore never runs out of fizz

The 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School will be in the spotlight today, its members having a gala Golden Jubilee Reunion on the campus. Never mind that none of the alumni from this batch made it to either the state or national team; the occasion still warrants a toast to the school's cricketing culture. Retro Route tracks the high points of the institution's cricketing history

Vivekananda Tournament, the finals was an all-Santhome affair. The school had entered two teams, Santhome 'A' and Santhome 'B', and these teams set up the summit clash. How they made it to the finals is in itself a plot that a 17th century writer from England would give his goose feather quill-wielding arm for. The finals left Santhome's cheerleaders in the gallery in a peculiar situation. In fact, the spectator zone was largely occupied by Santhomeans. When a boundary was hit, there was only cheers, no frowns. When a wicket fell, again only cheer, no glick faces at all, except for those of the opponents on the field. After all, the trophy was intact from the very beginning, sealed for Santhome; the spectators' fingernails were intact too, no nail-chewing nervousness.

Old bonds stay strong

You can take someone out of Santhome, but not Santhome out of them, according to Srinivasa Rao. He does not coach Santhome school anymore, but continues to feel a strong pull towards those gates. Every day, on his walk, he stops by the school and shares a word or two of cricketing wisdom

with the boys slugging it out in a routine practice match.

An unusual admission policy

Behind Santhome's cricketing dominance stood a group of people who put cricket on a pedestal. While recalling those Halcyon days, P. Unnikrishnan, the renowned playback singer and proud Santhomean, speaks fondly about then principal Brother Camillus, whose affection for cricket was impossible to miss. With a laugh, Unnikrishnan remembers how Brother Camillus had a unique yet simple admission policy that was at loggerheads with commonly followed protocols. "If one could play cricket, the rest could be sorted out later." Things were as simple as that in Brother Camillus's world. And that meant Unnikrishnan's report card from his previous school, Asan Memorial, stayed unseen. Unnikrishnan and Santhome had met mid-way, he looking for an environment conducive for growing his skills as a top-order batsman and a wicket keeper, and the school seeking a talent that would slot smoothly into a cricket restructuring plan it had drawn up. Unnikrishnan points out that the school was restructuring its cricket programme in the early 1980s. It did not take long for the institution to see results on account of this exercise.

"We won almost every tournament in the 1980s," he notes. According to the musician, part of Santhome's cricketing success in the 1980s derived from a scientific approach to the sport, partly epitomised by S. Ramakrishnan who

would later come to be known for his pioneering work in video and data analytics in cricket. "Ramakrishnan was my senior by a year and my captain in the Santhome team," the singer says. Today, the role of the support staff is often underlined when a team excels; Santhome has a robust support team, and Unnikrishnan has laudatory words for a few of them, including coach CPS Mani and Md. Hussain (manager of Santhome cricket team), who actually spotted Unnikrishnan's cricketing talent and brought him to Santhome. Champion teams win laurels not only by the strength of their own abilities, but also those of their arch rivals, clashes with them sharpening their skills. Unnikrishnan names Santhome's prime rivals in the 1980s: its neighbour on Santhome High Road, St. Bede's and The Hindu Higher Secondary School in Triplicane.

Santhomeans of 1976 to celebrate golden jubilee reunion today

The 1976 batch of Santhome Higher Secondary School will celebrate its Golden Jubilee Reunion on June 7 from 4 p.m. to 7.30 p.m. at the school auditorium.

As part of the celebrations, the alumni batch will donate 12 smart boards to their alma mater. The smart boards will be inaugurated during the function, says a press release.

The batch has also taken the initiative to establish and register an alumni association and launch a dedicated website to facilitate online membership registration and related banking transactions for alumni activities.

The 1976 batch originally comprised around 130 students across one English-medium section and two Tamil-medium

sections. Through extensive efforts, the organisers identified 65 former students, who are now connected through a WhatsApp group. Sadly, around 25 batchmates are no longer with them, the release adds.

The reunion is expected to draw nearly 80 alumni members along with their family members.

A special feature of the event will be the felicitation of 11 former teaching staff members and two office assistants who served the batch during their school years.

The event will also be attended by members of the newly formed Alumni Association committee, selected members of the current school staff, and invited senior and junior alumni of the institution.

Retro Route is a column that resurfaces the past that was Madras

Elders care centre launched

Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospital has launched Dr. K Elder Care Assisted Living.

Located in Nanganallur, the centre aims to address the growing need for professional elder care, assisted living, and post-hospital recovery services.

Dr. V. S. Natarajan, founder of Dr. V. S. Natarajan Geriatric Foundation, inaugurated the centre.

According to a press release, the facility offers a comprehensive range of services, including long-term assisted living, post-hospital recovery care, neuro-rehabilitation, palliative and end-of-life care, and respite care.

The facility is designed to provide a safe, comfortable, and medically supervised environment for senior citizens and patients requiring rehabilitation and ongoing sup-



port, the release added.

The facilities include doctor consultation suites, nursing supervision, physiotherapy services, medication management, wellness programs, and recreational spaces.

Dr. T. G. Sivaranjani, director, Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, says, "We have created a nurturing environment where seniors can live with dignity, comfort, safety, and access to professional medical support whenever needed."

Shelter at Anna University bus stop needs mending



The precariously hanging buses route number boards at the Anna University haltover. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Waiting at Anna University stop (on the lane towards Guindy) should get one's safety antennas up.

The roof of the shelter is

torn, and the structure leans forward. Furthermore, the stainless-steel structure supporting the roof is rusty. A row of boards denoting the route numbers is equally shaky and can fall. The stainless

steel structures roof serves little purpose during summer. Firstly, the roof absorbs heat and the overhead roof has to be expanded to provide commuters relief from the scorching heat. The route

number boards should denote the existing route numbers: 49, 49X, 49K, 49F, A47, 78, and 19. Zone 13 (Adyar) of the Greater Chennai Corporation should provide a new shelter at Anna University haltover.

Nominations invited for Teachers' Awards

The Shiv Nadar Foundation, in partnership with Said Business School, University of Oxford, has invited entries for the inaugural edition of 'India's Best Teachers' Awards 2026'

The awards are for educators of Geography, Business Studies and Entrepreneurship, Computer Science, Economics, Physics, English, Environmental Sciences, and Mathematics, teaching classes IX to XII.

Applications will be assessed on subject expertise, innovation in teaching methodology, impact on student learning outcomes, and leadership within schools and

communities, stated a release from the foundation.

School principals and heads of government and private schools can submit nominations until July 31 to <https://indiateacherawards.evalato.com/>

Shortlisted finalists will be invited to participate in the final stage of the awards process at Shiv Nadar University, New Delhi - New Capital Region on September 4 and 5.

Award recipients will receive national recognition and a fully funded scholarship to participate in a one-week learning and development programme at Said Business School.

Course on Montessori teacher training

The Indian Montessori Training Courses (IMTC), Chennai, will commence their 56th Montessori Primary Teacher Training Course later this month.

The course will include online and in-person sessions, a format designed to balance work, family, and a passion for early childhood education. The course will conclude in March 2027.

The successful candidates will be awarded a diploma by

the Indian Montessori Centre, Bengaluru.

As an introduction, IMTC-Chennai is holding a brief online orientation and walk-in demo sessions for aspiring teachers between June 8 and 12.

For details, WhatsApp and call 94449 36263, 044-24614301. Email: admissions.imtcc@gmail.com

Visit: <https://imtccennai.org>

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Will Metro Water ease these foot soldiers' everyday ordeal?

A hand pump at a public square and a community water connection in Sholinganallur need urgent attention

PRINCE FREDERICK

At School Road South in Sholinganallur, a memorial shelter approximates to a public square. Overlooking a pond and shaded by a sprawling banyan tree, the structure essentially meant for the local community to perform 16th day rituals of the deceased, recommends itself as an all-season hangout. And local residents act on that recommendation.

Under the maintenance of Ward 199 in Zone 15 of Greater Chennai Corporation, the structure is a roofed pavilion, largely open on the sides, thereby making for optimal ventilation, a factor encouraging people to have a spot of relaxation in a cloistered environ, particularly during summer.

The space hosting the structure has another utility, designed as an add-on, but comes with an everyday relevance. Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board (CMWSSB) had installed a hand pump, and the pump is worked vigorously every day, a



horde of people heading to it with pots; they do not have provisions for direct supply of water to their homes, many of which are hovels.

And the handle is now being worked up and down much harder, but that does not help. The water flow is slow despite the efforts.

School Road South has mixed housing. Apartments with round-the-clock amenities that can be had without raising one's little finger. And on the other hand, the road has pockets that wear blue-collar fatigues as well as present a vignette of the locality's pastoral past, rudely interrupted only around 20 years ago by the Information Technology juggernaut.

Arjunan is running late for work, and the lethargic flow of water is adding to his stress. He is a mason, and every man hour he gives his employer is significant, and the latter would frown on late-coming with a more twisted visage than would a supervisor at an IT company.

Arjunan notes that the water flow is slow for the last two months as the washer needs replacement.

Kuppuswamy, 77 years old, is not in gainful employment, but has

hardly retired to a life of ease and unaccountability. By the look of things, he never will. Under his breath, he mumbles that everyone at home wave their employed status at him, and march him off to the hand pump to fill ten pots of water in the morning.

He is also the baby sitter of the family, having been tasked with taking care of its youngest member while the rest are out earning the daily bread. CMWSSB can ease his burden in the mornings.

For the benefit of a group of low-income households, massed together at one spot, CMWSSB has provided water on tap, one connection for that settlement, but the tap is running dry.

If this provision had been productive, this enervated senior would have been spared the strain of working a stubborn hand pump.

Located at Kalaingar Karunanidhi Salai, the Sholinganallur Zone 15 office (Area XV) is not far from these spots, but the will to make things easy for people whose life is tough on any given day, seems to be light years away.

Kuppuswamy and Arjunan.